WEXMOOR FOUNDATION
Read. Teach. Lead.

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Outcomes Sought with Focus Areas: A Resource for Grantseekers

This document gives grantseekers a sense of the kinds of outcomes The Wexmoor Foundation is interested in supporting. It is not meant to be comprehensive. Instead, it offers a starting point for conversation as your organization considers its alignment with Foundation priorities or prepares a final application.

We know that there are many approaches to evaluation. Few organizations have the capacity to conduct large randomized controlled trials. Such studies are valuable, but we do not expect them of every grantee. Some organizations engage an outside evaluator, while others rely on their own staff to track progress through a standard assessment or performance management system. We want to hear about your process, and we recognize that budget, organizational stage and program complexity all shape an organization's approach.

Whatever method an organization uses, we are most interested in evaluation that drives learning and continuous improvement, rather than evaluation used only for compliance and reporting.

The Wexmoor Foundation supports work in three focus areas:

- **Early Grades Achievement:** Increasing the number of children in kindergarten through third grade who achieve on or above grade level in core subjects
- **Educators & Leaders:** Recruiting, developing and retaining excellent teachers and leaders in K-12 public schools
- **Extracurricular Activities:** Expanding students' participation in high-quality extracurricular activities that strengthen their engagement in school and support their growth in learning

The sections below describe the kinds of outcomes we most want to support in each focus area. Because the field of education changes quickly, no list of acceptable outcomes can be complete. Above all, we hope to talk with grantseekers about their approach and their use of data, how they know whether they are making a difference, and the theory of change behind their work.

Early Grades Achievement

Standardized test results, while sometimes debated, are linked to later life outcomes, and they give programs and funders a common baseline for comparing students and approaches. For that reason we value their thoughtful use. What interests us most, however, is the **growth** of an individual student or group of students over time, not a single score. Growth measures account for differences in where students start and offer a more meaningful picture of a program's contribution.

Test results should be complemented by other information, such as formative assessments, attendance, program evaluations and performance tasks, so that programs and the Foundation can stay focused on

improving student learning. We are especially interested in organizations that collect and analyze data for each student and use it to tailor instruction to that student's needs.

Suggested data points for grantseekers include:

- Summative and/or formative measures of student achievement
  - **Summative measures** are usually end-of-course or end-of-year assessments, such as the North Carolina End-of-Grade reading and mathematics tests or a nationally normed achievement test.
  - **Formative measures** show progress during the year and help teachers adjust instruction. Examples include universal literacy screeners, diagnostic reading assessments, curriculum-based measures and benchmark assessments.
- Additional measures that add context to achievement data
  - **Attendance**, including daily attendance and program participation records. Chronic absence can seriously slow a young child's progress in reading and mathematics.
  - **Feedback** from teachers, families and students.
  - **Student engagement and behavior**, including measures of attitude toward learning and disciplinary data.
  - **Performance tasks**, such as reading-response journals, projects or writing samples scored with a rubric.

Educators & Leaders

Teachers are the most important in-school influence on student achievement, and school leaders are critical, especially when it comes to keeping excellent teachers. Principals create the conditions in which great teaching and learning can happen.

The ultimate outcome we hope to see from our investments in teachers and leaders is **growth in student achievement**. We understand that it is complicated to measure how much any one educator contributes to an individual student's learning. That complexity does not remove the value of trying.

We invest in high-performing, results-focused, sustainable programs and strategies that advance these goals for teachers and leaders:

- Recruit the most qualified candidates into the profession
- Develop current educators so they can better help students achieve
- Retain the most effective educators

Recruitment and retention can be measured fairly directly. The harder question is what makes an educator "most qualified" or "most effective." We believe that several measures, including student learning, should inform that judgment, and that those measures should be grounded in evidence and research. We ask grantees to explain why the candidates they recruit, or the educators they work to retain, are the right ones, and to connect that explanation to our ultimate outcome: student achievement.

Examples of measures grantees might use include:

- Candidate quality and placement, such as performance during clinical experiences, licensure results, and hiring into high-need schools
- Educator effectiveness, such as student growth data, structured classroom observations and student surveys
- Retention and mobility of effective teachers and principals, especially in high-poverty schools
- Educator experience, such as working-conditions and coaching surveys

A Word on Professional Learning

Teachers and leaders, as adult learners, deserve high-quality opportunities to improve their craft. There are many approaches to professional learning. When we assess professional learning investments, we look for programs that are:

- **Collaborative:** Educators learn in teams committed to continuous improvement and shared responsibility for students.
- **Led well:** Skilled leaders build capacity, protect time for learning and create systems that support it.
- **Data-informed:** Student, educator and system data are used to plan, assess and improve the learning.
- **Practice-based:** Learning includes modeling, rehearsal and feedback connected to educators' real classrooms.
- **Sustained:** Support continues long enough to change practice, with coaching during implementation.

- **Aligned:** Learning goals connect to educator performance standards and to what students are expected to learn.

Extracurricular Activities

Extracurricular activities extend students' learning beyond the regular classroom and give them additional ways to engage with school. As in our other focus areas, participation alone does not tell us whether a program is making a difference. What interests us most is the **growth** of an individual student or group of students over time, and evidence that taking part is connected to stronger engagement and learning.

We understand that activities offered outside the regular school day vary widely in their goals and design, and that measuring their contribution to student learning can be complicated. That complexity does not remove the value of trying. We want to hear how each program defines success, how it collects data for each participating student, and how it uses that information to improve.

Examples of measures grantees might use include:

- Participation and attendance
  - **Attendance**, including daily attendance and program participation records. Chronic absence can seriously slow a young child's progress in reading and mathematics.
- Student experience and engagement
  - **Student engagement and behavior**, including measures of attitude toward learning and disciplinary data.
  - **Feedback** from teachers, families and students.
- Evidence of learning
  - **Performance tasks**, such as projects or writing samples scored with a rubric.
  - Where a program aims to support academic progress, **summative and/or formative measures** of student achievement, such as those described for Early Grades Achievement.

As with all of our investments, we are most interested in evaluation that drives learning and continuous improvement, rather than evaluation used only for compliance and reporting.